



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Light of Christ Academy
School Website: <https://lightofchristacademy.org/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Light of Christ Academy (Augusta, MI) demonstrates a robust classical-Catholic educational model that blends Montessori foundations with liberal-arts classical instruction. The school emphasizes a Catholic theological framework, virtue formation, and the liberal-arts progression (grammar, logic, rhetoric) through Great Books, Socratic inquiry, and a deliberately immersive liturgical/catechetical environment. Public materials show daily Mass, catechesis, a formal Montessori Atrium, Great Books study, Socratic dialogue, and explicit statements about forming the whole person toward truth, goodness, and beauty. Taken together with faculty and family involvement evidenced on site, the school aligns strongly with the six classical elements rubric.

- Overall classification: CLASSICAL across all six categories.
- Executive synthesis: The public-facing materials consistently foreground Catholic formation, virtue, truth-goodness-beauty, a triadic pedagogy (Montessori + classical), and active parental involvement. The Great Books, Socratic pedagogy in upper grades, and a theological-virtue-centered approach are repeated through multiple pages and staff profiles. This combination indicates a coherent classical-education identity rather than only a partial classical alignment.

Evidence and keyword analysis underpinning the six-category assessment are drawn directly from Light of Christ Academy's public materials and the classical rubric lexicon in the knowledge base.

- Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: Catholic identity is explicit (daily Mass, chaplaincy, catechesis, liturgical life). Positive religious/metaphysical keywords are abundant (Catholic, Mass, Catechesis of the Good Shepherd, liturgy, adoration, virtue, theological and cardinal virtues, the True-Good-Beautiful). A clearly negative signal is the absence of vocational-education framing and explicit secular metaphysical commitments. The balance strongly favors the classical element of transcendental moral realism and liturgical community.
 - Key citations: daily Mass at 8:15 a.m. and chaplain presence; Catechesis of the Good Shepherd; theological virtues and the True/Good/Beautiful framing.
- Purpose and Goal: The school speaks in terms of formation, wisdom, virtue, truth-goodness-beauty, and formation of character rather than mere job-preparation. Positive keywords include formation, virtue, wisdom, truth, goodness, beauty, the true-good-beautiful trinity. Negative signals (e.g., "workforce" as a sole aim) are present only in contrastive statements describing classical aims. The weight of evidence supports a fully classical aim.
 - Key citations: "formation of the whole person in wisdom and virtue," "education becomes an adventure in human formation... not mere preparation for the workforce."
- Curriculum: The Great Books / Great Conversation core, grammar-logic-rhetoric progression, and history embedded through curriculum are clearly stated. The Montessori grammar/logic/rhetoric structure is acknowledged alongside classical curriculum elements (Great Books, Socratic discussion, rhetoric, Latin). Positive indicators dominate; explicit Great Books/Great Conversation references and the grammar-logic-rhetoric continuum underpin the category.
 - Key citations: Great Books and Socratic Method; grammar/logic/rhetoric; history embedded; Great Conversation; inclusion of wonder.

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- **Pedagogy:** A dual approach is evident: lower-school emphasis on memory, chant, and wonder (contemplative/experiential elements) and upper-school emphasis on Socratic discussion, seminars, and rhetorical training. The presence of a three-stage pedagogy aligned with classical theory is explicit, including the “three-hour work cycle” and “Atrium” concepts. The pedagogy is explicitly described as contemplative/restful at points, with rigorous Socratic work in upper grades.
 - Key citations: lower-school chanting and memorization; upper-school Socratic seminars and rhetoric training; Atrium-based Montessori framework.
 - **Faculty:** The public materials present a faculty that models virtue and expertise (principal, director, chaplain, teachers, staff). The faculty is positioned as a core element of the school’s identity (e.g., principal and montessori program director, chaplain, music and other subject specialists). While explicit “living-curriculum” language is not always verbatim on the site, the staff portraits, virtues quotes, and Catholic formation orientation convey a strong, virtuous, mentor-style faculty posture.
 - Key citations: named faculty roles (Principal, Director of Montessori Program, Chaplain) and staff bios signaling virtuous leadership and formation.
 - **Parents & Community:** The school emphasizes parents as primary educators (Montessori page), invites visits/open enrollment, and hosts community events and program involvement. Positive signals include “We respect the parent as the primary educator,” “Plan a Visit or take a virtual tour,” and ongoing parish/school-family integration (Mass, catechesis, service, and community life).
 - Key citations: “We respect the parent as the primary educator,” “Plan a Visit,” “open enrollment,” and Catholic-parish community life.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

- **Evidence**
 - Daily Mass and chaplain presence indicate liturgical life and communal worship as a core element.
 - Catechesis of the Good Shepherd and Catholic environment are woven into Montessori and upper-classical programs.
 - Theological and cardinal virtues are explicitly foregrounded; the True, the Good, and the Beautiful are central to the formation aim.
- **Positive/Negative keyword analysis**
 - Positive: Catholic; Mass; Catechesis of the Good Shepherd; liturgical life; adoration; virtue; The True, the Good, and the Beautiful; theological roots.
 - Negative: Workforce-focused framing is present only as a comparative caution, not as a primary aim. The explicit workforce-oriented language is limited to negating a purely vocational aim.
- **Why this rating**
 - Strong Catholic identity and liturgical life; explicit formation around truth/goodness/beauty; catechesis integrated with classical curriculum anchor this category as CLASSICAL.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- **Evidence**
 - The school frames education as formation toward wisdom and virtue rather than mere information or job preparation.
 - The Great Books/Great Conversation emphasis and the aim toward truth, goodness, and beauty are repeatedly stated.
 - The triad of Truth, Goodness, Beauty is embedded in the heart of the mission and virtue formation.
- **Positive/Negative keyword analysis**
 - Positive: formation; wisdom; virtue; truth; goodness; beauty; Great Books; Great Conversation; wonder; the True-Good-Beautiful triad.
 - Negative: explicit workforce/job framing is de-emphasized in favor of formation; workforce language appears only as a negation, not as the school’s aim.
- **Why this rating**

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- The overarching goal is the formation of character and intellect in light of transcendent realities, not merely preparation for work, aligning with CLASSICAL.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Liberal-arts structure of grammar, logic, rhetoric is described within the program; Great Books and the Great Conversation are central; history is studied in a broad, integrated manner rather than as “social studies.”
 - Montessori grammar/logic/rhetoric framework is described (Atrium, memorization, poetry, hymns, chants).
 - Latin instruction and classical reading/writing are present; emphasis on poetry and recitation.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive: Great Books; Great Conversation; rhetoric; grammar; logic; history across the curriculum; Latin; poetry; hymns; chants; wonder; memorization.
 - Negative: none prominent; the site does not emphasize “social studies” or a non-liberal-arts emphasis. (The explicit emphasis on liberal-arts and Great Books is the core signal.)
- Why this rating
 - The curriculum weaves Great Books and classical progression with Montessori elements in a way that strongly supports a CLASSICAL orientation.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Contemplative/restful aspects are acknowledged in the pedagogy (lower grades: memory, chant, wonder; upper grades: Socratic discussion, seminars, debate, rhetoric).
 - Lower-school singing/chanting and memorization; upper-school Socratic discussion and rhetoric training; opportunities for public speaking.
 - The plan includes Socratic method in high school and a grammar-logic-rhetoric progression, plus Great Books discussions.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive: contemplative/Scholé; singing and chanting; memorization; wonder; Socratic method; seminars; rhetoric; Great Books discussions.
 - Negative: no explicit counter-signal; the presence of contemplative/restful pedagogy is not a detractor in classical models when balanced with Socratic rigor.
- Why this rating
 - The pedagogy explicitly aligns with classic pedagogy (Scholé-style contemplative elements alongside rigorous Socratic and rhetorical training). CLASSICAL.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Faculty profiles show a mix of roles (Principal, Director of Montessori Program, Chaplain, teachers, staff), with visible emphasis on virtue and leadership within a Catholic-formation frame. This aligns with the “living curriculum” ethos described in classical education rubrics.
 - The principal quotes and staff bios emphasize virtue, service, and faith-informed teaching, signaling a faculty culture that models character and virtue.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive: model teachers; mentors; living curriculum; portrait of teacher; virtue; Catholic identity (as reflected in staff roles and bios).
 - Negative: explicit “living curriculum” phrasing is not always verbatim on-site, but the conveyed meaning is consistent with the criterion.
- Why this rating

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- The staff structure and bios demonstrate a classical-faculty ethos (virtue, mentorship, formation) that supports a CLASSICAL rating.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Montessori page explicitly states “We respect the parent as the primary educator of the child,” signaling a strong partnership with families.
 - The school invites visits and offers open enrollment, plan-a-visit language, and parish-community integration (Mass, catechesis, service).
 - Service formation and family/community life (Mass, catechesis, service to parish) reflect ongoing engagement with parents and the broader Catholic community.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive: parent as primary educator; co-educators; plan a visit/open enrollment (parents welcomed to visits); parish-community life; family atmosphere; service and community engagement.
 - Negative: no significant negative signals; the site strongly emphasizes parental partnership.
- Why this rating
 - Strong and explicit parental involvement signals (parents as co-educators, visits, and Catholic community life) match CLASSICAL expectations.

Aggregate assessment: CLASSICAL

- The school demonstrates consistent alignment with the classical education rubric across all six categories. The presence of Great Books, Socratic pedagogy, a robust Catholic formation, and a family-centered, virtue-focused environment collectively support a CLASSICAL designation.

What would move the needle

- If the goal were to elevate from CLASSICAL to a more “fully integrated Classical” standard in every nuance, the school could:
 - More explicitly codify and publish a concise, category-by-category mapping of positive/negative keyword indicators to the rubric (for external evaluators) and provide direct quotes tying each element to rubric criteria (e.g., “living curriculum” language in staff communications).
 - Provide a more explicit articulation of how lower grades’ contemplative/restful pedagogy connects to upper-grade Socratic pedagogy with a formal, published framework or handbook.
 - Expand public-facing statements on parent partnerships beyond the Montessori emphasis to include more formal co-teaching practices or parent-professional development opportunities (e.g., book studies, class-wide seminars) to strengthen the Parents & Community category as an explicit co-educator model.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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